After Iran became an Islamic theocracy in 1979, the new regime made it compulsory for women to wear the hijab. But the Iranian morality police found it difficult to enforce this rule. They couldn't place a police officer on every street corner, and public confrontations with women who went unveiled occasionally aroused resistance and resentment. In 2022, Iran relegated much of the job of enforcing the hijab laws to a countrywide system of facial recognition algorithms that relentlessly monitor both physical spaces and online environments.[30] A top Iranian official explained that the system would 'identify inappropriate and unusual movements' including 'failure to observe hijab laws'. The head of Iran's parliamentary legal and judicial committee, Mousa Ghazanfarabadi, said in another interview that 'the use of face recording cameras can systematically implement this task and reduce the presence of the police, as a result of which there will be no more clashes between the police and citizens'.[31]

Shortly afterwards, on 16 September 2022, 22-year-old Mahsa Amini died in the custody of Iran's morality police, after being arrested for not wearing her hijab properly.[32] A wave of protests erupted, known as the 'Woman, Life, Freedom' movement. Hundreds of thousands of women and girls removed their headscarves, and some publicly burned their hijabs and danced around the bonfires. To clamp down on the protests, Iranian authorities once again turned to their AI surveillance system, which relies on facial recognition software, geolocation, analysis of web traffic and pre-existing databases. More than 19,000 people were arrested throughout Iran, and more than 500 were killed.[33]

On 8 April 2023, Iran's chief of police announced that beginning on 15 April 2023, an intense new campaign would ramp up the use of facial recognition technology. In particular, algorithms would henceforth identify women who choose not to wear a headscarf while travelling in a vehicle, and automatically issue them an SMS warning. If a woman was caught repeating the offence, she would be ordered to immobilise her car for a predetermined period, and if she failed to comply, the car would be confiscated.[34]

Two months later, on 14 June 2023, the spokesperson of Iran's police boasted that the automated surveillance system sent almost one million SMS warning messages to women who had been captured unveiled in their private cars. The system was apparently able to automatically determine